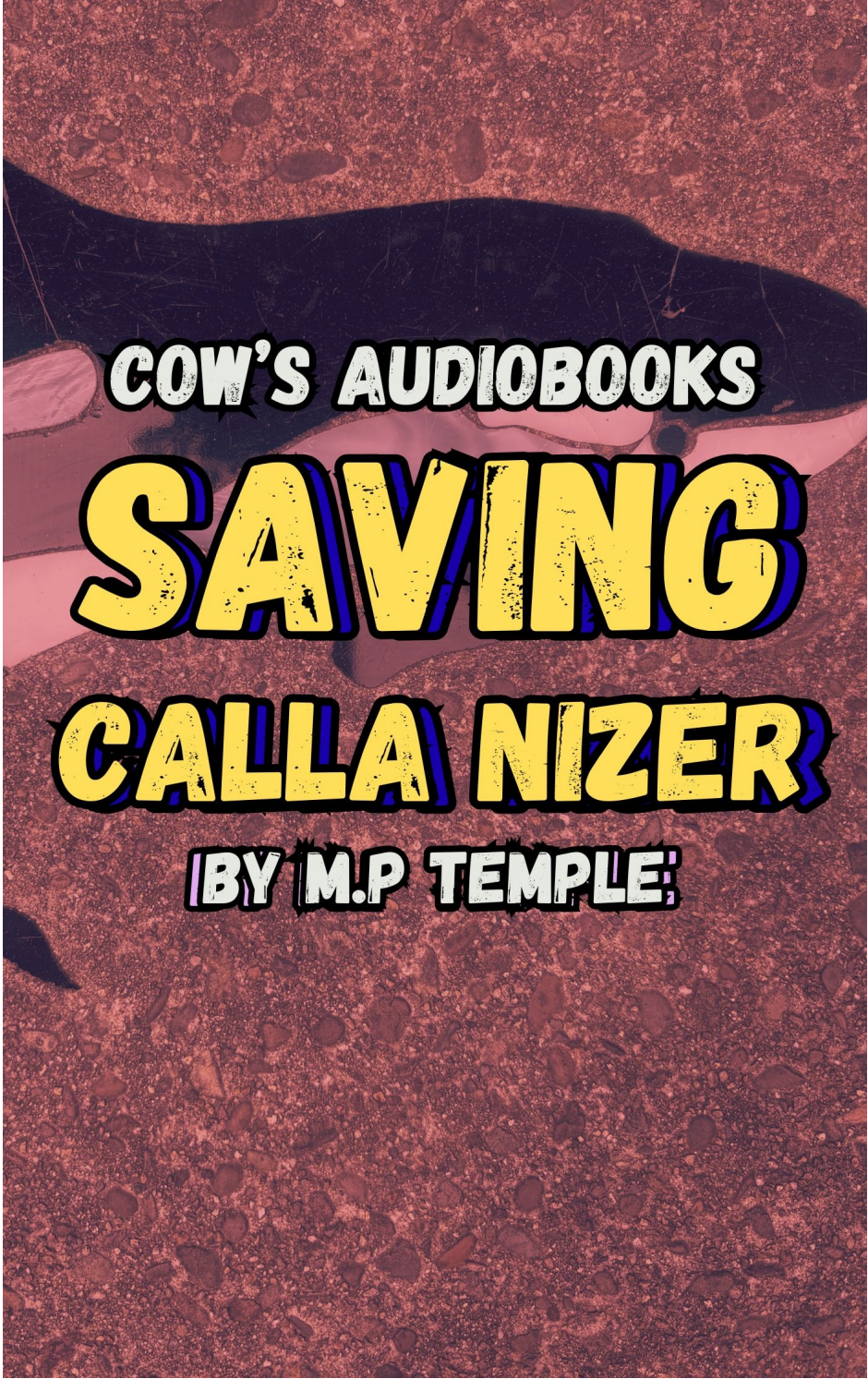




COW'S AUDIOBOOKS

SAVING

CALLA NIZER

BY M.P. TEMPLE!

Episode 1: First Contact



Dear Earth Person,

You are hereby formally invited to dinner with the standing ruler of the planet Artubia at your convenience. I will be telling you everything you need to know to prepare for this once in a lifetime honour throughout this story I am about to tell. This story is about how we on Artubia met our first Earth person, named Calla Nizer. Because of this, your attendance is requested.

Far from your planet, far from anything your instruments have ever measured, is our home planet of Artubia. Our ‘dwarf planet’ is surrounded by 26 moons. If you can imagine that many moons in the sky above you blocking out the sun, we recommend that you do not bring sunglasses with you. You won’t want to miss any of the wonderful sights our red, rocky planet has to offer. From research that we have done on all the trash your planet keeps sending out, we believe the area around Cedar City Utah, might be a close fit to what you will experience here on our planet. It’s just a lot colder.

Also, please inform whoever it is who needs to know, we do not wish to purchase AOL internet. Please stop sending them our way. The disks keep ending up here, and when they crash into our moons, they cause a little spark in the sky. At first it was pleasant, but the nonstop sparkles have got old.

So picture a southern Utah like planet with a small mall hovering above it. Here is where our story begins. Wataful Martin, King of Artubia and head of the grand Martin family, has decided to step down. To decide which of his children become ruler of our planet, a sports game was played. We call this 'Fireball'. It's like air hockey played in zero g with two players with lacrosse-like sticks, attempting to fling a bright blue fireball into a net. One can also score points for catching their opponent on fire. From our research into your excessive trash, we believe this style of sport should be satisfactory to your violent tastes. This event is held in the Sky Mall above the planet's atmosphere so the oxygen can be cut off before serious harm is done to a player. We understand this might be disappointing to you on earth. With your thirst for blood and suffering and everything.

Ten seconds remained in the final match between

eighteen-year-old Etoile Lambert and twenty-one-year-old Soreen Martin. The Martin family members, and selected non-family, cheered in the arena adjacent to the food court. They watched as the royal Martins stood with their sticks in the court below, separated by a strong glass viewable chamber.

Etoile had trained for years for this moment. For this was the only path she had to becoming queen. The score was 6-7. The princess of Artubia only needed one more score in the net to go ahead by 2, thus ending the game. The entire planet, and every civilisation living on each of its twenty-six moons was almost hers.

The Martin family booed at her as the court ready light went on, alerting the players that the clock was running. Etoile extended the stick and picked up the fireball. Instead of launching it at the corner of the net where she knew Soreen struggled to defend against, she chucked it at his waist. But the puck went off course, flying toward his crotch. Etoile gasped and held her hand to her mouth.

Soreen's lower body caught fire. He screamed and ran around his side of the court. Crying, "No fair!" The fire timer started. If he kept burning for five seconds, she would be rewarded a point. There were six seconds left on the arena clock. She crossed her arms as the fire puck

floated across to her. With two seconds remaining, and Soreen still crying, rolling around in the air in a panic, she picked up the blue fireball and sent it rocking into Soreen's net.

The final score, 6-8.

Normal gravity and airflow was returned to the court chamber. In celebration, Etoile ripped off the top layer of her fire-resistant suit and screamed in excitement. She raised her fist into the air and wept tears of joy. The years of hard work and training against the family favourite had paid off. So she thought.

When she looked up to the stands in the chamber above, she saw that almost everyone had left the mall already. There was no confetti or banners as she had expected. Even though the first non-Martin had won the throne in a hundred years. Everyone had left in protest. The only thing she saw was a janitor turning off the remaining lights and locking all the doors. Including the one to Etoile's locker with all her street clothes. She protested, screaming, 'Don't lock the queen's locker! I command you!'

But Bud Martin wasn't listening. He had his wired headphones in and was lost in his new age space jazz.

Under the last flickering neon light over the arena, Etoile Lambert realised she was alone.



Martin Palace, Planet Artubia.

Etoile lucked out finding our local space taxi driver, Sol Del Sun, and hitching a ride down to her home in Martinville. That's in 'Martin County C7' in a grand structure that overlooks the majestic red and purple mountain ranges. We call it 'Bunch of Rocks Mountain'.

When Etoile entered her home, carved into the caverns that lead down to the below surface ocean, she made her way to her room through the halls filled with balloons. But the door to her suite was locked. From the main entertainment room below, she heard the clattering of a crowd.

One of the suns shone brightly through the glass building structure, facing the base of Bunch of Rocks Mountain. Here, members of the Martin family hung banners that read, "Good Try Soreen".

At seeing this, Etoile stormed downstairs past the crowd, ripping down every banner she passed by. The nerve of

the family.

She found the king standing next to stacks of grilled meat, helping himself to the burnt ends and extra pieces. The king quickly took a bite out of his corn on a cob before dropping everything to wipe his hands.

“Oh, look, everybody. Etoile the cheater has arrived home.” The king said.

Etoile, still wearing her half ripped top with a purple shirt underneath, flipped a plate of corn onto the white stone floor.

“What the flip is up with these banners?” Etoile shouted. “Soreen lost. I won using none of the game’s loopholes I know about. I deserve a celebration like a Martin would have received.”

The king shook his head and helped himself to another piece of grilled corn. “I demand you apologise to Soreen for the cheap shot. Tell my son that you are sorry that you suck and that he may never have children of his own!”

“There is nothing in the rulebook against that kind of shot. You all are... I demand to speak to you, Wataful alone.”

Wataful pounded his fist on the table to get everyone's attention. The crowd looked to him.

“Etoile and I are going to have a private conversation, but I don't want to go anywhere. So all of you must cover your ears and talk amongst yourselves. Not too loud, but loud enough that you can't hear what we are saying. Please proceed.”

Everyone did as what was asked and covered their ears with their hands and talked nonsense. Except Franicus Martin, who used the time to talk about his love of space trains. There are no space trains, and Franicus knows this. But how cool would it be if they really existed?

“I am the next queen. I will not apologise for what is rightfully mine. This is only because I am a Lambert. Not a Martin.”

“Of course, that is why. You know the family doesn't sugarcoat it, we are powdered sugar donuts. With extra sugar coating! We are proud. That's not why at all. We just don't like the outcome. It has been decided, by me, the great and awesome, that you are given this choice. Either you offer a rematch to Soreen so that he may take his rightful place on the throne. Or you are banished from the planet! I will not have another talk about you

understanding your place in the family. You knew I had a plan, and you actively went against the very smart plan. You are a Lambert. That is a fact I can not change.”

Etoile tore the rest of her suit, leaving her wearing only her undershirt and shorts. She found a drink on a silver platter and chugged it down in a single gulp.

She said. “Here’s a fact you can’t change. I won. I will be ruler of this planet.”

“Okay, everyone.” The king said to his people. At first, no one heard him, since everyone was talking with their ears covered, but after a few loud shouts, he was able to get their attention. “Gather all of Etoile’s things and throw them out of the palace. She is to be off the planet in twelve hours.”

“Twelve hours!” Etoile repeated. “There’s hardly a way to get a ride to the SkyMall, much less off the planet until next cycle. That’s not enough time for me to charter a flight out of here. This is no way to treat a queen!”

“You are nothing, Etoile Lambert. Only Martin’s family members are worthy of being loved. That is the lesson you must learn. Please proceed.”

At that, the other members of the family dragged Etoile out of the palace.



Sol Del Sun home, Out of Cavern Residence 404.

After picking through her belongings on the street in front of the palace, she set out to seek one of the few people she knew might help her the planet. But the strange space cab driver was not in his trailer. Although most of the ships he flew could not travel far from Artubia, she hoped that one of the crashed tourist ships might be fixable. Maybe a ship that had mistakenly thought that the skymall had a tractor beam that pulled their vehicle into the parking bay. When you visit Artubia you won't be allowed to fly anything, ever. But know that tractor beams do not work in this area of the galaxy.

For the larger part of an hour she searched through piles of wreckage, pulling up computer terminals and wiring. She tossed the usable pieces into a pile outside Sol Del Sun's trailer. None of the smashed hulls of the ships seemed repairable, much less recognisable as spacecraft.

Etoile heard a pounding sound. It seemed to be coming

from something in a nearby massive pit. A pit full of discarded, crushed wreckage. At the bottom, hardly visible in the rubbish, sat a foreign-looking ship. The words “Made in Missouri” were painted on the ship’s outer silver saucer.

The princess climbed down into the pit, finding her grip on sharp edges and slippery dents in the wreckage metal. She found her way down to where the pounding was coming from. Only from being so close to the ship could she hear a voice that had a strange twang quality to it.

“A little help in here?! My radio ain’t working!” The voice cried out.

The first thing you will learn quickly upon arriving to Artubia is that there are no radios. Don’t ask for the password to our WiFi either, there is no WIFI. Walkie Talkies? They don’t work. You can leave behind your Bluetooth headphones as well, they won’t be able to connect. There is so much solar radiation and cosmic rays in our solar system that it interferes with everything over the air. Sure, our planet naturally shields us enough to keep us alive. But not enough to get a clear signal. If you want to listen to something on the trip over here, you best bring a pair of wired headphones. Oh, and every once in a while solar flares wipe out all the electronics

on the planet. So you might want to bring a book.

Of course, Etoile's first response to hearing the trapped travellers complaint about not receiving a radio signal was "Well no duh. You can't park down there either, there's a sign!"

The person on the ship began to yell louder. "My ship's computer is off and I can't get the front hatch open!"

"I shouldn't be able to hear you if your ship is thick enough to with stand the solar elements." Etoile shouted down into the pit. "There's no way you're not glowing like a night light with radiation. You might want to get yourself tested for poisoning."

"Is that why my bone marrow hurts?" The woman said. "Find a way to get me out of this ship! Quick like!"

Etoile ascended further into the pit towards the trapped traveller until she found the hatch below the main saucer section. The ship looked as you would expect as U.F.O to look like. The lower side, close to the hatch, was the observation lookout for the craft. In the room at the top of the ship, visible through the cracked glass like dome, sat a field of sunflowers. There she saw a woman run towards her from inside. She wore a brown cowboy hat and an oversized hoodie with text across the chest.

‘Veni, vidi, vici.’ Whatever that means.

The woman’s eyes grew large when she saw Etoile, who was struggling to find her footing as she moved towards the main hatch.

“Oh, my Seattle. You is an alien with them purple eyes!” The woman shouted.

Etoile sighed. We love our tourist visitors. But they do suck sometimes.

“No, I mean they’re pretty! I just ain’t seen an alien before.”

“I’m a person.” Etoile informed her.

“And my name is Anakin!” the other human shouted back.

Etoile had no idea what she was talking about. She was regretting that she had bothered to trouble herself. She was risking serious injury, or death, to come save her. Yet, here she was making some kind of pop culture reference that is assumed everyone is going to know.

“Um. Hello Anakin. Welcome to Artubia,” Etoile said.

“I was kidding!” The traveller shouted. “My name ain’t Anakin. I’m Nizer. Calla Nizer. I am from the planet

earth. I have come to form a peaceful alliance with any planets I come across.”

“Right, Calla Nizer, how do I get this hatch open?”

Calla pointed below. “My interface ain’t interfacing with the main computer! All my wireless devices doing done smit. Nothing. Hey, how are you able to understand English like I do if you’re one of them aliens?”

“We are human! And I’m not understanding you well at all. Let’s try another Earth language.[whale noises] Como este’? ...Konichiwa! Doko ushi?’ You don’t seem to understand any of those. Never mind, I’m going to find some way to break the dome and get you out of there.”

“No!” Calla waved her hands and ran around the edge of the dome. “It took me five years and prolonged my mission last time I replaced that! You’ll have to convince the AI bot Clip to open the hatch. I can’t talk to him from here. Just ask em, and that should get me out of here in no time spit!”

Etoile, after a few moments, gathered she meant that she needs to verbally request the hatch to open at the main terminal.

She made her way over to the entrance of the spacecraft

and pressed on the screen of the terminal firmly.

“Don’t tap too hard! I’m sensitive!” The computer said. Awkwardly.

“... No. I don’t trust your AI. I’m going to break the glass.” Etoile said, finding a sharp metal rod left in the remains of one of the tourist vehicles who could not figure out how to use their turn signals.

[Glass breaks]



Martin Care Centre

“Wow, you aliens give out candy at the hospitals too! Though this candy corn on a stick ain’t as good as one of our dum dums.”

At this point, the earth person’s nasally voice had begun to sound like nails on a chalkboard to Etoile. She was frustrated from waiting for the treatment to be completed. But it was, after all, the Administration of Medication’s most extreme case of space sickness ever.

“Again, like I said two times before, we are both human. Just from different planets. I’m lucky I found you when I

did,” Etoile told the annoying earth person. “You would have started your half-life if I hadn’t found you. Calla Nizer.”

The nurse came into the room and removed the needle from the earth person’s large vein in her forearm. After an IV drip and two triple plant burgers with vegan cheese, Calla’s colour now looked more human than fading ghost.

Etoile went on with her thought. “It’s amazing you made it out here so far. Without any kind of clue whatsoever.”

“That’s how we do it on Earth. We will power everything into happening or burst!” Calla said. “Oh. Speaking of bust, how much is this medical bill gonna set me back? I ain’t got much more than a few hundred pounds of sunflower seeds to trade with. I had health insurance back on Earth, but I reckon that was about two thousand years ago. Gee. Paying all them premiums didn’t do much for me, did they? Anyway, in other words. How much I fixing to pay y’all for saving my life?”

Etoile blankly stared at the Earth person. Confused. The nurse shrugged her shoulders, also not sure what earth pop culture reference she was referring to. Even more confusing, the nurse signalled that the space traveller

was free to go. But she didn't do anything.

"I don't understand." The Earth person said.

"... you're... free to go." Etoile said, speaking up for the nurse who could not find any words to speak.

"...Speak straight to me! I'm prepared to repay my debt, whatever it be. Do I get a bill later or something?" Calla demanded.

"We don't know what you are talking about. You sound like you think you are getting charged for a service? They don't... make you pay money on earth to get better when you're sick, do they?"

The space traveller crossed her arms and let out a huff. She shouted at the top of her lungs. "I didn't come thousands of light years just to get preached at! Am I lying back and thinking of Joplin or not?!"

The woman panted, nervous. As if she expected a wild animal to attack or something.

The nurse approached her and gently placed a hand on her shoulder. "We are glad you feel better. Welcome to Artubia. Come back in a few weeks so we can check to make sure you have all the vitamins and nutrients you need. Have a good day. ... You can leave now." Again the

nurse gestured towards the door.

“Earth person,” Etoile said, also slowly approaching her.
“Why are you crying?”

The earth person could not speak with all the tears rolling down her cheeks. Instead, and to Etoile’s surprise, Calla grabbed hold of her shirt. She sobbed uncontrollably.

“I don’t understand.” Calla wept. “Am I your slave now cause I got sick?”

“Who hurt you?”



Martin Palace, King’s Study.

“Has the earth person stopped crying?” The king asked.

Etoile nodded yes. “We got her ice cream at the SkyMall food court, and she calmed down. I’m going back to check on her soon when Sol Del Sun has a chance to pick me up.”

The banners and the after party trash had been cleaned up (and not tossed out into space like some planets

do...). The palace was spotless, with the scent of blossoming flowers. I'd like to note that while on our planet, you should not pick anything unless instructed to. Some of our plants like to bite back. Or have effects that you might not be expecting. Such as blindness or an instant feeling of external dread. You should ask one of our professionals before touching anything.

"That poor thing," said the king, overlooking Mt. Bunch of Rocks. "I've always taught you that the universe is cruel. Though, from all the research on their space trash, I guess we should have known they had issues."

"Her ship is fuming with radiation and electronic malfunctions. There's no way she should have been sent out into space in this condition. While I search for a way off the planet, please take her in for me. Until she can either find her way back into the sky, or. Maybe she might like it here. If she has come this far, then maybe she can be saved."

Wataful Martin poured himself a glass of blue flavoured water and thought over the situation.

"I spoke with the nurse who treated our guest. She said Calla frightened her. She thinks the woman is capable of violence. And I agree. I can not risk the safety of my

family. You know this. Martins first.”

“Then let me stay. And watch over her. Let me prove to everyone that non-Martins are people too. And if I can convince everyone of that? Then I don’t have to ask Soreen for a rematch. You will hand the crown to me.”

“You?” the king asked. “Try to rehabilitate an earth person? Earth is arrogant, simple-minded and controlling planet from the information we have gathered. Calla Nizer is dangerous.”

“Artubia is for everyone.” Etoile said. “That is the visitor centre gift shop motto. And you are king to all people. As I will be when I am Queen. I hate the Earthlings too. But we have to ask ourselves what our humanity really means.”

“Hmm. Your dedication to this is interesting, but promising. I agree to your terms. You will use all of your education I have given to you. And you will teach Calla how to be a respected Artubian citizen. She must prove her worth as a true Martin. You are the official ambassador of Earth. Please proceed”

“Ugh,” Etoile said. “Gross. But, I will not let you down. Can you unlock my room now?”

There came a knocking at the study door. A messenger entered in a panic. “There is a problem at the Skymall. Some foreign plant-ter is trying to trade sunflower seeds for the rights to the ice cream stand. She says she wants to ‘franchise’?”

Etoile sighed heavily. “I’ll talk to her.”



SkyMall Food Court.

“You see, not everyone everywhere should have to be so worried about money so much that they can’t function.” Etoile told Calla over another serving of hot chocolate and ice cream. “We have learned from our other visitor friends that when someone isn’t used to getting what they need, they start hoarding things. This idea to ‘franchise’ sounds like that. Now, it’s okay that you are confused. You got some very heavy treatment that messed with your head. That and I’m sure of all the isolation can make people a little batty. Everything is okay. You aren’t in trouble. You are going to come with me to live in the palace.”

The space traveller’s eyes narrowed. “Don’t you wanna

make some money? In case stuff ever gets bad and you need it?”

“It’s fine to prepare. But. You see that flower?” Etoile pointed to a plant growing in a pot near the rubbish bins. “It’s okay to enjoy it but we don’t need to...”

“Wow! That’s pretty!” Calla said, rushing to the flower. “I’m gonna take it with me!”

“Wait!” Etoile shouted. But it was too late. Calla picked the red flower, which caused a loud snap.

“Why am I so sad suddenly?” Calla asked.

“Don’t pick the red ones. Pick the green ones.”

Calla searched the planter box and found a green one. She plucked it, and the sour expression of dread flushed from her face.

“As I was saying... we can learn a lot more from listening than speaking and taking.” Etoile continued, throwing both of their ice cream containers away. “Normally, you shouldn’t go around plucking flowers. These are here for the children. It keeps them busy while they update their personal devices with the latest data that’s out. If you want to fit in here, then I want you to remember these two things. Observe. Don’t conquer. You don’t have to

control everything. You can be a part of it.”

Calla pulled something from her hoodie pocket. A weathered laser pistol, with a long, black, worn barrel. She pointed it at Etoile, who shrugged and took a sharp breath.

When she didn’t acknowledge her threat, Calla said. “I’ve seen enough bad stuff happen on holodecks to know something ain’t right. Am I dead? Is this a cult planet that is gonna eat my heart out?”

“You’re delusional. Go ahead. Shoot me and find out.” Etoile said. She grabbed the barrel and stepped towards the weapon. “Go ahead. Find out what happens when you turn to violence. And anger.”

“Don’t tell me what to do. You speak to me like I’m a child, well I know what I’m doing!”

“Sure you do.” Etoile said. “Shoot the laser. Go ahead.”

“If I shoot you, I might not stop. I might try to take over this entire planet. Run it like I would!”

“Okay,” Etoile said. “Start with me, then. Go on. Or are you too weak!?”

Calla gritted her teeth and pulled the trigger. Then

gasped. The weapon discharged, but instead of a deadly beam, a bright light shone out. This light moved slowly, like a glowing snail in the air. Etoile gently blew on what should have been the kill shot. When she did, the light disappeared into the air.

“Lasers don’t work here.” Etoile said. “Light swords don’t work either.”

“... My. Weapons don’t work? Not even light stabby sword?”

“No. If you must fight, you must do it with words.”

“Oh no.” the earth person said darkly.

“We start tomorrow. Early in the morning. We got moon paths to avoid and sites to see.”

Etoile realised this was going to be a lot harder than she thought.



Episode 2: Hell Day



Space Taxi Garage. Sol Del Sun property.

The local taxi driver/mechanic determined that the earth people's spacecraft was unfit for interstellar travel. Which is not surprising, from the wear and tear of travel and incredibly poor spaceship design. The Ozark 9000's computer system was cooled by lasers, and thus was completely worthless. Its turntable like simulated gravity now spun out of control. Being that Etoile had to help Calla not walk in circles for days, it seemed ill-advised, yet immoral, to ever send a living person up to travel on it.

"I can get 'er parked in a cave if you want me to. The Ozark would make a fine house," Sol Del Sun said, trying not to nod off while sitting on a chair in the centre of the packed garage. A few taxi vessels sat with their solar sails removed for patching and repairs.

"She'd like that," Etoile said. "The earth person has been worried because she thinks she is 'homeless'". She inspected the sides of the refurbished craft.

"Homeless? You mean people with no homes? I don't get it. Do they let people wander around with no shelter for funzies?" Sol Del Sun asked.

"Yeah. And I guess they play loud music and put spikes on things so they have nowhere to go. It's illegal to give

them food too, apparently.”

“Something ain’t right with that planet. Nothing good can come from a place like that. There’s no way you’re gonna get the Martins to like her. Not with all that baggage.”

“If she made it this far,” Etoile said. “She can’t be worthless. There has to be something in her that is lovable. I just have to find it.”

Sun Del Sun shook his head. “Once I picked up some Gronkroulawn worshippers back when I lived on Ispep. They are a bunch of loonies whose religion requires them to hurt and annoy people cause of some living space monster.”

“That’s insane. Nothing lives in space.” Etoile laughed.

“These jerks think so. Anyways, so these people stiff me and tell me they can’t pay me, right? I tried for weeks to reason with those people. They were so set on making everything for me so miserable and refuse to discuss a way to pay their debit. I even offered to let them pay me back later. But there was no changing their minds. So I ejected them on the nearest inhabitable planet and left them there. There are normal humans like us. And then there are the others who are deader than cryovolcano

roses in winter. You've seen those clips from earth films they show all the kids here. Any planet that can make a movie like 'Garbage Pail Kids' can not be saved."

Sol Del Sun shook his head before putting on a pair of large googles. He went on. "Good luck with that. I gotta get out of here, I'm supposed to be taking a fare to Skyobject and my ship's computer is bugged out. You know. I'm worried there's more where she came from. What if she found some interstellar shortcut from their solar system? And she is going to bring the rest of them?"

Etoile shivered at the thought of there being more than one Earth person in a room. "Good Martin, let's hope not. I'm going to drag Calla Nizer to Hell Day Celebration. Maybe if she engages in some good old Artubian sport that will bring out the best in her."



Guest Room. Martin Palace.

Every year on our wonderful planet, the hot, salty ocean beneath our surface experiences intense storms. These cause our cryovolcanos, or hot ocean water geysers in this case, to erupt. More than usual. This causes dust

storms on the surface. You see, all life here evolved around these hot saltwater vents. This is where we get our water and our plants. So we celebrate Hell Day. The key part of the festivities is dumping water on the ground around our cities so that it cuts down on dust that can be blown away.

Etoile explained this to Calla, who struggled to understand how volcanos here don't have lava. What helped her to understand it was it's like going to a very cold water park with hot water spraying everywhere to make it warm. And once a year people make a skating rink out of the park so that no one gets hurt in the dust storm.

"So you're telling me there's a log ride on Hell Day? Cause I'm in if there's one of them." Calla said.

"I want you to go. As my guest." Etoile said, looking at her sitting on the bed. The curtains were drawn, and her things were cluttered about in the otherwise eloquent room. To her, she looked like many travellers who found their way to us. Yet so different. The earth person seemed too caught up in her own past. Her eyes focused on all the wrong things at the wrong times. How does one even help someone like that?

“I mean.” Calla fell silent. “I stopped getting sick finally. I could use some sunlight, I suppose. Alright. I’ll go. Let me grab my sunglasses.”

“You won’t need those. Ever.” Etoile said.



Bobartion Martin Memorial Park and Walking Path.

The earth person was very confused at first seeing Martin city. It’s located at the base of the cryovolcano known as the Darthony Martin Ocean Vent. Children dressed warmly were placing decorated kites into the cracks of the towering geyser in the centre of our city. Grown adults were walking around, spraying water that slowly dropped to the ground to wet the surface.

Oh, I forgot to mention. Gravity here isn’t like it is on Earth. It’s about thirty-five percent less. Things might feel different, so it’s important to start considering how this might impact you when you get here. So if you weigh yourself and you are ten pounds lighter, don’t freak out.

Anyway, Hell day takes place when our largest moon Buddy, about half the size of Artubia, eclipses the closest sun on the 357 day of our 478 day year. Fun fact: the

name for our closest sun is bigger sun. The other one is called sad sun. It's sad. Cause it's small. We do have a sense of humour.

Moments before the daily lunar eclipse took place, people huddled together. They all were looking at the thirteen suspended moon in the vast sky above them. Waiting for the kites to launch.

“Gosh,” the earth person said. “I wish I could have made a kite. This looks like a lot of fun! What do they do once everything is up in the air?”

Etoile looked down and rubbed the back of her neck in shame. “It's. A thing only true Martins are allowed to do.” She said.

“Oh.... So. Only they get to have fun then?”

“Martins are the only ones who matter here. I'm sorry that we are messed up like that. I'm sure for all the faults your planet has, no one on Earth has to experience prejudice.”

“So that's what racism feels like... Oh my god,” Calla said. “Tup pac was right all along.”

“Why are you sad again, Earth person? Please tell me they at least treat you all horribly, equally.”

For some reason, Calla coughed and looked off into the distance. Etoile at this point knew what to expect from an earth person's emotional breakdown. Which is, of course, buying something, or seeking one or another addiction they might have. We had already figured this from our research on all the trash you keep sending our way. But Etoile, seeing Calla cheer up after yet another ice cream purchase, was alarmed.

"So. You're like, totally the only one who is coming to our planet, right? No one else from Earth will be joining us?" Etoile asked.

Calla gave her a long, cold stare. "I know when I ain't liked." She said.

"That's not what I meant," Etoile invited her to move closer to the geysers, whose vents let out a loud sizzle. The Martin children grew excited for the launch and prepared to go running after the kites.

"You've been judging me this whole time. You all think you are better than me." Calla said.

"No. I staked my entire political career on you. Because I believe everyone is worthy of love. You are seeing ghosts of assumptions rather than the truth. Because you are still trying to conquer. You constantly feel the need to

prod and poke. Like you think that is the only way to solve any complicated issue.”

“Being from Missoura, I take offence to that,” Calla said. “Folks really did give up and settle in Taberville. Being like, ‘Yup. It’s flat. Guess we’ll stay here forever.’”

Not to sound like a broken record, but again, we do not understand your pop culture references.

“I am going to teach you how to be Artubian, Calla Nizer. It’s easy. Listen. And you will see. My adoptive brother Soreen wants to meet you. Walk with me.”



Centre of the Celebration. Near the park and ride for public mass driver 2.

“Ah, yes. You are the whale lover,” Soreen said in a thick accent differing from others on Artubia. “from that trash panda world that keeps sending ET games into space.” “LOoK aT mE. I dOn’T kNoW hOw tO rEcYcLe!”

“We recycle! We just get confused about what bin to put what item in!” Calla shouted.

“Who do you think you are, sir!”

Soreen drew back on hearing this. He tilted his head and made a face, then signalled for his trusted servants to come near. “Hold on a minute. Why are you calling me by my gender? That’s weird.”

“I’m being polite. SIR.”

“That is ill manners from where I come from. WOMAN PERSON!”

“What else am I supposed to call you then? No one here has manners, I swear it.” Calla said to Etoile, whose hands covered her face to hide her embarrassment.

She briefly pulled Calla to the side and whispered. “Observe. Don’t conquer. You got this.”

Calla brushed herself off and approached the prince. Who was examining his nails, chewing on the bits he didn’t like.

“Cultural misunderstanding. My bad,” Calla said, turning to Etoile. She nodded.

“My greatness is hard to comprehend, yes. You are forgiven.” Soreen bellowed. “Tell me about your journey. Do you miss your whales?”

“Why do you keep talking about those water mammals?”

“The Voyager golden record track listing contained mention of a humpback singing. And those brainwave scans about love. We are smart enough to figure out love affair when we see it.”

“Not all people love whales, some people on Earth kill them and make oil out of them!”

The servants gasped. Soreen took hold of the side of a glasshouse and put a hand to his heart. “That is the saddest thing I’ve ever heard. Tell me. Do they turn everything they love to oil on Earth?”

“... basically.” Calla admitted.

One servant wept.

“I’m sorry. I need a moment. My heart hurts.” Soreen said.

Before he could walk away, Calla grabbed a ball of snow. “Come on now, don’t feel sad! I got a way to cheer everyone up. Hey Etoile! Look out!”

Calla threw the ball of snow towards the princess. However, after spending so long in space with a turntable gravity system, Calla’s arms had not adjusted to real gravity. You see, with her form of artificial gravity, throwing something requires a little of a curve to it.

Since everything is spinning. Her muscle memory took over, and the snowball did not hit Etoile. Instead, like one of those baseball game things you all love so much, it curved sharply. Smacking Prince Soreen in the face. Slowly, that is. It kind of softly floated over, really.

The servants screamed in horror. Bodyguards appeared, having been watching him the entire time, and tackled the earth person.

Someone shouted. “The whale killer tried to assassinate Prince Soreen!”

“Wait! I was playing! Don’t tell me you don’t have...”

Etoile pulled the guards off Calla. “She didn’t mean it! They don’t know how to play nice on Earth!”

Soreen stood and ordered the guards to stand Calla up. His face was red from the impact. He has sensitive skin. “I am placing you under arrest. For attempted murder!”



Palace chamber.

“Your Majesty, I dun request a continuance. Until my lawyer can get here. He lives in Omaha, I suppose that’s

about four thousand light - years from here. Being a United States citizen, I got rights to due process. *Afroyim v. Rusk*, 1967. Now, if you want to deport me, I understand. But this is a cultural misunderstanding. And I apologise for messing up your holy holiday.”

The king, sitting on his throne, looked at Calla kneeling before him, shaking. Etoile stood next to her, and tried placing a hand on her shoulder to comfort the frightened human. But she withdrew when she flinched.

“Your Majesty?” The king said laughing. “You seem to feel the need to constantly label everything. And assume. Stand up, you’re making me nervous. We don’t worship people here. I’m starting to think getting arrested means something different to you. We um. Aren’t going to make you into oil if that is what you are worried about. Soreen is okay. We are here to try to help you better fit into our culture. You seem to be struggling.”

Calla tried to stand, but her knees buckled. She leaned on Etoile. “I really need y’all to stop being so nice. I’m so afraid I’m going to find out you eat each other for food, or some sort of twist.”

“... you don’t eat people, do you?” Etoile asked.

“What kind of question is that! Not usually!”

“On Artubia,” King Wataful said, changing the subject. “We don’t throw things at people. Please see Soreen and explain to him what kind of earth game you were playing. Play a little nicer now Calla Nizer. Okay?”

“Okay.”



Later. Hallway outside of guest room.

“Come on, Earth person. You can’t stay in there forever. Come outside.” Etoile called out. No response came. “It’s snowing outside. Do you want to build a snowman?”

The door suddenly swung open. “You can’t say that! Disney will find you.”

Etoile was delighted to see the human after days of her hiding out. But was uncertain about what she was upset about this time.

“Do... they do something wrong to the snowmen on earth?” Etoile asked.

“It’s copyrighted! Look. I can’t get nothing right. I can’t

risk talking to nobody or doing nothing. I gotta figure out what to do. I don't belong here."

"Yes, you do." Etoile said. "You have to give us time to learn about you. So we can both adjust."

"All you do is say how bad I am every time I say stuff. It's always has to be about how great it is here in your little cult paradise." Calla said.

"That's why we need you. So I can help everyone understand. We can end this Martin running everything stranglehold. They are going to love you. Like I do."

Calla deeply sighed. "I'm flattered, but. I'm not that kind of earth person."

"No!" Etoile stomped her feet. "Why is this so difficult for you? How can I help?"

"I want to be at peace. I don't think I can do that here. You are too perfect!"

Calla slammed the door. Before Etoile could do anything, Soreen came storming down the hallway with his trusted servants.

"I need to speak to Calla," Soreen declared. "I need to know that the whales are okay."



Spare guest dinning room. Palace.

Etoile invited her adoptive brother into the next room, a glass blown room overlooking Bigger sun' s sun set. Leaving smaller sun in the sky around six moons. Bunch of Rock Mountain cast a large shadow on the land.

“She doesn’t want to talk to anyone. Calla Nizer feels worthless here. You have to help me.” Etoile said.

“You want me to assist with my assassin?” Soreen said. “The words that whale oiler speaks! Everything about her is stained with her curse! What on Artubia do you want my help for, anyway?”

“We need an event. Meant to teach our people about her culture. So we can better understand what she is going through.”

“You want me to go to things? Never!”

“The family respects you, the last of the Martin bloodline. They listen to you.” Etoile said. “They don’t listen to me.”

“Very well then.” Soreen said. “I will throw your. Earth

Party. HOWEVER! I have but one condition. Calla Nizer must seek... counselling!”

Etoile’s eyes widened. “That’s impossible! No Artubian has the experience in handling that level of trauma. She’s stubborn, she’d eat our experts alive. Like they do to their own whales!”

“That is the agreement.” Soreen flung his hand in the air in dismissal. “There is hope. The one you seek lives on SkyObject24601! An alien named. Bork. Bork Mindu. A chap who once helped me out years ago. Tell him I sent you. And wish his mother hello for me. Ask her if she ever found that set of dice with the faces of Garbobians.”

“I’m not going to remember all of that.”

“Write it down! Because what you don’t understand about this human is that we as a grand society, are what the earth people might call. Soft. She is a hardened vermin from a poor, war driven people. It is by her nature to act upon these forces from her past. If you can not tame what is naturally a part of her? Then she can never be a real Artubian.

Etoile sighed. “I’m agreeing to take her to Skyobject24601. To see Bork Mindu. But note my objection. No one person can save her. It’s going to take

all of us.”

“Fat chance,” Soreen said, walking promptly towards the room’s exit. “I only came up with that cause I don’t think she can handle it. It will be the last of her, wait around and see.”

“There’s something special about her. I know.”



Guest Room, palace.

“Calla! Open up I have good news.”

No stirring came from inside the room. After knocking, she decided to use her key to check on the poor traveller. But when she got inside, there was no one there. All of Calla’s things were removed. The Earth person was gone.

All that remained was a heavily shielded tablet with a movie playing. Star Martin Episode Six, The Return of the Void Kisser.

Etoile’s mouth fell open at the sight.

“That movie isn’t available to download yet. I heard they finished filming it a few days ago”.

We'd like to note here a few days here is a few months on Earth. The rotation of our planet around the sun takes longer than yours. Which is okay with us. No need to rush, is there?

“Did she... hack this?” Etoile said.

She searched the rest of the tablet and found dozens of books on the Artubian writing system. And a process which we call simply “Coding.”

“What is she doing?” Etoile threw the tablet at the wall. It softly hit and fell to the floor gracefully. What kind of information was she after?

The sound of footsteps filled the hall. A small team of palace messengers entered into the room. “Princess! Sol Del Sun wishes it to be known to you that he had resolved his ship's computer issue with the help of a stranger. He is lifting off, but would like you to check on the earth person's ship that is ready for transport. He says he doesn't trust earth people cause they are not capable of helping themselves. Prepare in case the trash panda double-crosses you perhaps. ”

Etoile cursed. But paused. “Well. At least she is headed towards Bork Mindu. I just have to find her in a giant flying city.”

“What do you mean, my princess?”

“I bet earth person is with Sun del Sun hiding on that ship somewhere. In fact, I know it.”

The Earth person’s ship might not have been rated for long distance space travel, but this did not matter to Etoile. After booting up the rewired ship’s system, she was able to launch the ship off of public mass driver number 1. With some struggle, since your writing system is incredibly hard to learn and understand, and you didn’t leave us with a lot of help there, Etoile set a course. To sail on the solar winds that would take her to SkyObject24601. She couldn’t let this human ruin her chance of ruling Artubia.

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Episode 3: To Catch An Earth Person

★⁺▪₊) ○ (₊▪⁺

Calla’s Space Ship. Orbit of Artubia

Etoile hit the side of the computer with her fists. The ship would soon reach it’s periapsis in its holding pattern in the orbit of Artubia. If the ship was to clear the 26

moons, the burn would need to start soon.

The computer said, “I see you are trying to travel to StarObject24601. Would you like to know more about the quickest path through one of your moons? Or would you like to talk about how StarObject should be PlanetObject since it’s a planet and not a star?”

Etoile shouted. “No one knew what planets were when they named it ages ago, and NO! Give me back control of my ship, you stupid AI. If you don’t, we are both going to die!”

“Not me.” Said Clip. “I’m in AI bot. I have no end.”

“Clip. Shut down.”

“Okay. I’m shut down. That was fun. What would you like to do next? Maybe about what to expect while reaching the centre of that moon?”

Etoile checked the time. 10 seconds until it was too late to change course. In a panic, she went with the first idea that entered her mind.

“Let’s play a game!”

“Like Skyrim!” Clip said.

“... No more buggy earth games. You go hide in a folder

somewhere, and I'll go looking for you."

"Oh! I like games. Watch the controls while I'm gone. And count backwards from 100!"

The control lock light switched off. Etoile increased the throttle to full and began counting, slow and missing a few numbers as she went along. But with the ship's course corrected, the craft whistled past Buddy the moon, towards the prison planet.



StarObect24601.

Without a light sail, the trip to the floating city had taken much longer than expected. She also spent several hours in the orbiting line waiting to land. Of course, landing in a windy upper atmosphere is difficult, so when you come to visit, expect a rough landing. That and the floor shaking the entire time from the massive currents running under your feet nonstop. Here you don't want to ever be on the surface. Bad hot, crushing things go on there. But high above, life is relaxing once you get used to it. But after landing, it took Etoile a few minutes to stop being sick from the turntable gravity from Calla's

ship.

Once her world stopped spinning enough for her to walk, she travelled to the Artubian wing of the city. Where Martins stayed and others could check themselves in. But when she got there, the doors were locked. In fact, all the doors to every building were locked. The usually busy glass streets had no one lingering.

Even stranger, all the computer links had been snapped off. The moment Etoile picked up the data connection cable to inspect it, the surrounding screens lit up with a message.

‘DO NOT CONNECT TO NETWORK. Someone has hijacked our nodes. Connecting will infect your device and will give control to the first bad actor in our history.’

“Dang it Calla Nizer,” Etoile cursed. She powered down her tablet. If things were that bad here, how were things back home?

She searched for several minutes, looking for anyone who hadn’t just landed like her. Or to piece together what had happened. But all she found was a cat. Playing with a leaf in the park.

It was when she stopped to play with the kitty, because

of course she was going to do that, that she felt something slightly hot and crispy softly crack against her skull. Calla stood with a large loaf of bread above her. Etoile sighed as Calla repeatedly hit her.

“Really, y’all, this is the best you could do for a weapon? We really all need to get together, everyone, and come up with some standards. I gotta whip y’all into shape somehow. Are we doing knives or guns? Are we getting stabby or maybe someone can brainstorm something, maybe?”

Etoile sighed again. “No one wants to be whipped into shape. They want to be left alone. What are you doing?”

“I have failed you, friend,” Calla said. “I can’t. Just not control things. I have taken over this prison. Not that I’ve run into anyone yet since I took over everyone’s computers, but I practically am ruler here”.

Etoile could only mumble. “Okay.”

“I had to take over this here floating city. I mean, they ain’t even heard of a shiv before. Someone has to set them straight.”

“And you hit me with bread, why?” Etoile asked.

“Oh, to knock you out so we didn’t have to have this

conversation. But I'll have to find some sort of harder food, I suppose."

"Please undo whatever you did to everyone's computers and come back home."

"I can't go back. I can't live up to your lofty standards." Calla took a large bite of the bread and chewed for a while. "Can you believe this is free?"

"You are ruining a lot of people's vacations. You aren't accomplishing anything. Please come home."

"It ain't my home."

"Yes, it is. You belong with us."

"You're just saying that cause you bet your entire political career on turning me into some kind of example. That seems to have backfired on ya uh? I read all 'em messages."

"There is good in you. I know."

"I keep telling ya, you can't go quoting stuff without citing your sources! Disney is going to come get you. I can not be changed. I'm a rotten apple. I belong here. With the criminals"

"With who?"

Calla offered Etoile bread, who politely refused. “Ya know. People who break the law. Like prison?”

“I’m not following.” Etoile said. “Prison is where you go to get away for a while. Where you go to sit in hot tubs and play outdoor games? People check themselves into prison all the time. Parents take their kids to go bake with the inmates. Some people even come here to live cause they need structure in their lives. Wataful has even been here a few times.”

“I could make a joke here. But I feel I shouldn’t.” Calla said. “You mean. They ain’t all. Thieves and jaywalkers?”

“Not always. That... isn’t what you do on Earth to people who need help, is it?”

“I think we should stop talking about that sort of thing. I don’t like getting political.”

“Is that what Earth people say when they don’t want their beliefs questioned?”

“You know too much. Okay. I’ll remove my program that hijacks everyone’s node and I’ll apologise. I really screwed up this time. How can I even go back? Everyone is going to hate me.”

“More than likely.” Etoile said. Not being helpful in the slightest. “But there is time to change their minds. They aren’t going to trust you. But you can earn that back too.”

“I can’t be that kinda person. I’m going to keep messing up the same way over and over. I need launched out into space for good.”

“The idea had occurred to me,” Etoile remarked.

“Give me your computer. I’ll restore everything.”

Without hesitation, Etoile did as she asked. A smile came across the traveller’s face.

“Y’all are so gullible. Sorry to have to do this, but now I can use this to get into the main tower.”

“Calla Nizer!” Etoile shouted. But it was useless. Calla had run off.

“I got to get her to Bork Mindu.”



Hidden Base, SkyObject24601

“Does anyone have any questions?” Etoile asked the

small crowd gathered around her and the kitty she met in the park earlier. Who spent most of the meeting holding up her paw.

“What is a question mark? The voyager guy said their continent was in the shape of a question mark? Are we as a people supposed to know what that means?”

“I don’t know. Anyone else?”

Someone asked, “Why did they send us naked drawings?”

“Does anyone have a question that is not about the confusing gold records on the voyager probe?”

Another person spoke up. “Actually, no, I have more questions. When the humans launched that into space, was the entire planet on some sort of mind altering substance?”

“I will not be fielding any more questions about the probe.” Etoile said. “Calla Nizer is weak, emotionally unstable, traumatised, irrational, has poor hygiene and talks funny. But she keeps finding ways to revert to her true nature. Does anyone have any questions or ideas on how to capture her so we can get her to therapy?”

No one in the crowd spoke. Other than the cat who found this the perfect time to meow loudly.

“Then we are sticking to the plan. Once the trap is set, we throw the weighted blankets on her and we take her to the tower.”



Near Skyobject Main Tower of Control and Healing.

Etoile watched as Calla slowly approached the setup in the park. The earth person constantly looked around her until she got within a distance of having a good line of sight of the sign with tons of bright spotlights pointed at it. The wind picked up, almost sending Etoile out into the open from her hiding spot behind one of the large trees.

“Oh, hell yeah!” The earth person cried, running towards their trap. At seeing this, Etoile moved towards her. The grass tickling her thighs as she ran.

But Calla stopped. She said, “Hold on a dang second. That ain’t no slice of Casey’s Pizza. Why these people don’t even know what pizza is!”

Etoile tapped Calla on the shoulder. “We have pizza here, and it’s much better than yours. Who puts the cheese under the sauce?”

“Are you trying to trick me?!” Calla yelled.

Before Calla could run, Etoile did something unexpected. She pushed the earth person towards the plate and shouted. “Now!”

Once Calla tripped over the plate, a heavy blanket attached high above a tree fell. Slowly, of course. Calla held onto her hat as she tried to dash out of the incoming trap, but it fell enough that she could not escape.

“You’re going to therapy!” Etoile shouted at her.

Calla laughed. “Look at you! That didn’t look much like observing to me. Good on you for choosing violence.”

Etoile looked to her hands, realising what she had done. She felt just as trash panda as the trash panda.



Tower of Control and Healing. Counselling wing.

“This here ain’t right!” Calla yelled. Etoile unwrapped the weighted blanket off her so that she could freely move about the large dark room. Lit only by volcano looking lamps glowing in a dim shimmer.

“We are here to help.” Etoile said again, for the dozenth time.

“You’re here to impose your cult like ways on folks.”

“That is exactly what you are doing to us, Calla Nizer!”

Both of them fell silent when a door opened and a large green and blue creature walked through. The alien had gills for a mouth and tentacle like hair. It looked over notes on a clipboard that it held.

“Oh,” the alien said. “You are from the whale planet. The very first! This is amazing. It is nice to meet you. Traveller from Earth. I’m Bork Mindu. And I’m here to talk you about your home planet. A subject that I must tell you I gave my professional capstone on.”

“Can I leave now?” Calla asked. “I don’t want to talk about feelings with talking puppets.”

Bork Mindu’s face grew sad as he picked up a box marked “puppets”. With one of his arms he put the box out of view. Etoile sat down in the chair farthest away from the two and observed.

“There ain’t nothing wrong with where I come from. Folks are secretly judgemental is all.” Calla said.

“Who isn’t judgemental?” Bork asked. “Isn’t that sort of behaviour there to protect them from the unknown?”

“The hell should I know, You’re the expert.” Calla stood and paced about the room in front of the alien therapist.

“Are you trying to escape by wearing a hole in the floor? I should remind you we aren’t anywhere remotely near solid land up here. Here. Take this. Unless in your culture you like to use your fingers.”

Bork brightened the light in the room and held out a paintbrush.

“What is this?”

“A tool that you dip into paint to make art with.” Bork said.

“No, why are we bothering doing this?”

“Just take the brush. We are going to pretend there is a window in this room and both of us are going to paint some gentle clouds. Remember. There are no mistakes here. Let it out on the canvas.”

Calla shook her head no, but started to outline a window on the canvas in front of her, anyway.

“That’s good.” Bork said. “Maybe add one of those earth

whales in there.”

Calla’s nose wrinkled at hearing this. “Whales don’t live in the sky.”

Bork shrugged. “Well. Maybe you should have included a photo of them in that probe of yours. Tell me. Where you come from you are expected to do something most of the time?”

“Working. Only honest way to live. If you ain’t working, you ain’t contributing to nothing.” Calla yawned. “Sorry for that.”

Bork’s hair stuck up at hearing this. “Are. You apologising for yawning?”

“Well. Yeah, it’s a sign of weakness.” Calla said.

“You are a mammal. Delightfully lazy creatures who then get all worked up and accomplish months’ worth of work in a week. From my research on humans in the galaxy that is. I uh, have a paperback out if you’re interested after, but never mind that for now. My point is, you are by nature supposed to be lazy sometimes. It sounds like you are so traumatised you have been mentally conditioned to fear retaliation from such a simple sigh.”

“Earth ain’t that bad. We are strong. Intelligent.”

Etoile watched Bork set out some more paints to use in her sunset cloudy sky artwork. “How long did it take you all to get into space? I imagine this was achieved a few thousand years after your kind of human species evolved to speak.”

“I um,” Calla blushed. “Hundred thousand years or something. Is that unique to people?”

Bork paused for a long while. “Well. Not everything has to be a race. It’s okay if you all are... a little slow.”

Calla flung a chunk of paint towards Bork’s painting. Soaking his shirt in yellow.

“Retaliation. Oh, this is interesting.” Bork said. “Any kind of perceived weakness is bad. Stomped out, I bet. If I were trying to keep a bunch of lifeforms under my control, I’d make sure everyone had to think like that too I suppose.”

“I ain’t about to start talking politics.”

“I don’t know what anyone believes on your planet. Other than your trash problem. I can only tell you, me an expert in human behaviour, what I see. And that is you must be from one of the worst places in the universe. Imagine a species that has no value for life. No value of

it's self. It's the most incredible thing I've ever seen."

"I have no use for your feelings, Doc."

"Of course you don't! Not growing up in that hellscape of a world that you did. That's why you are so out of touch with reality. You were taught that your feelings were wrong. But feelings are like these clouds we are painting. We don't have to always engage. But we can acknowledge. You can pretend they don't exist. But isn't the whole picture so much better when we let them be? Unless you are some kind of cloud denier."

"Okay," Calla said. "I feel annoyed that I'm standing here watercolouring instead of something important. Like. I know stuff at home wasn't right. That's why I left. I just. Can't fit in anywhere else. But I can't hurt. It made me tough. Much more so than anyone here. If I don't do something, y'all are gonna get your butts kicked. By, I don't know, the paper people planet."

"Oh, Calla Nizer," Bork said. "You hurt so much that it could rip a hole in spacetime. It's so bad that your presence in this room hurts. You were just taught that feeling was wrong. By the way, paper people planet are very peaceful and welcoming. I get a card shipped from someone there every 20 years or so."

Calla sat up straight and spit on the ground. “The only way I can get y’all to understand is to create a little chaos. That’s why I sent my ship on the mass driver while everyone was having their little meeting. It’s headed to one of them tiny moons of Artubia. That’ll destabilise every thing!”

Etoile pushed aside Bork Mindu and got into Calla’s face. “What did you do!? People live on those moons!” She yelled.

Bork Mindu put away his things and shook his head. He told them. “She is re-creating her home world. So that everyone is suffering as much as she is. Because Calla Nizer doesn’t know how to adapt. It is my opinion that Earth people are incapable of love.”

Calla’s face turned ghost white. She let out a gasp. “Is. That what I’m doing? But that’s the reason I left my home planet.”

“I have to catch up to that ship before it hits any of our 26 moons.” Said Etoile. “Then I have to get used to the idea that I will never be Queen. Earth people can’t be saved. I have failed my people.”

Etoile left the room. But not before overhearing Bork and Calla talk.

“Have. I been the bad guy from Die Hard all this time?” Calla asked.

“Is that one of your films?” Bork asked. “I’ve never found a copy of it in your garbage if it is.”



Episode 4 Artubia Can Take It!



Borrowed Space Craft, Orbit of Nazadozamo

Catching an object hurling through space isn’t as easy as some of your Earth films make it out to be. The mass driver that sent the Ozark 9000 up is one of the most powerful craft propulsion system anywhere in our galaxy. Since it uses the planet’s hydrogen as nearly an unlimited energy supply found on Starobject24601, a light sail alone would not be fast enough to catch up. For this, Etoile calculated only the only path to stop the destabilisation of the moons. But she had to return to a place she swore she never would. The moon of Nazadozamo. A five hundred mile wide moon with an atmosphere, visited by those only looking for its isolation. This is where Etoile was found as a baby before

she was sent to Artubia. A place she had felt dread as she approached in her borrowed spacecraft. She figured it was Bork Mindu's since a large sticker on the outside read "Get help".

She had no time to think about that now. Instead, she flicked her communication light, hoping someone on the planet's orbiting station would spot her. Through a series of short and long flashes, she signalled to the men looking out the observation tower of the station.

"No transfer."

She couldn't risk the virus node spreading to the Nazadozamo. Etoile had not even turned on her personal computer since Calla infected every device. StarObject's network was already down. She only needed the gravity assist from the planet. Nothing else.

But the men in the tower waved to her and signalled back in light messages "We have new Martin Wars!"

Etoile tried to perform a barrel roll on the craft, but the drone size ship locked on and docked in the data port. She did everything she could to stop the transfer, but it was too late. Her ship's computer chimed. It updated her gossip protocol to the latest shared data and messages across the Martin net. In a place she had not been since

she was an infant.

“New Interaction Audio Message. Open now?” The main computer said.

The name on the screen of the sender sent Etoile into an emotional spiral. From the log, the message was from someone she had never even spoken to. Someone she never expected to speak to.

The sender’s title read simply “Dad.”

Etoile opened the message and held her hand to her mouth as she listened.

“Hey Etoile. It’s me. The scumbag who gave you up. Dad. I hoped you would come here someday. I programmed this interactive message to be sent to you if you ever came back to the place I made the hardest choice I ever had to make. My dearest Etoile Lambert, you were not abandoned. We gave you up because we have a mission, a destiny as a family to fulfil. I hope you are here as queen of Artbuia. Looking for answers. Are you ready to hear what you must do? Or do you have other questions first?”

Etoile could not believe what she was hearing. “I guess. Why maybe?”

“The Lamberts needed you to get close to Wataful. Your placement in infiltrating their class must be successful if you are here. Our family has kept a secret for many generations. By the time you hear this, I’ll be gone. You will be the last of us. But you are the only one who can do what we need done.”

“What is it that I must do to fulfil my legacy?” Etoile asked.

“In this double binary solar system lives an asteroid sized creature. Its species evolved around crater impacts. We encountered this intelligent life a long time ago. We were tasked with one thing. To appease the cosmic leviathan, as they might call it on Earth, everyone on Artubia must be sacrificed.”

“What the...?!” Etoile yelled.

“The easiest way would be to destabilise that mess of 26 moons. But with the people trusting you, the ways to do it are endless. Gronkroulawn finds pleasure in suffering. None of us have been able to appease Gronkroulawn’s thirst. But we have two planets that we can destroy. The second can only be reached from a wormhole in the depths of space. Travel there and go through. On the other side, you will find the place your name came from.

A planet named Earth.”

“Um... no,” Etoile said. “I’m not doing any of that.”

“If you do not. The universe will be destroyed.”

Etoile shook her head in disbelief. “My dad is completely mental. There’s no way anything lives in space. Not without its blood boiling. Everything you speak is pure madness. It’s impossible.”

“Gronkroulawn has a hard, outer asteroid like shell. It is on the inside where the life of the creature lives. Do these deeds. Or be prepared to face wrath. Fulfil your destiny. Oh, our family also doesn’t like Sanervals, or anyone on the paper planet. Cause as much suffering as you can! Step on dog tails. Steal your roommates favourite pen. Leave the milk out on purple. display as many hateful messages as you can! Bring forth Chaos, my child! The universe is counting on you.”

“This can’t be,” Etoile said, making her way to the window so she could look at the moon outside. Clouds of bright blue storms swirled in its atmosphere. “I don’t want to be queen to destroy. I want to be queen to heal.” She said.

“Gronkroulawn will smite the weak!” Her dad said

through the interactive message.

Etoile turned off the message and sank into the chair in front of the manual controls. Her heart sank as thoughts began racing through her head.

“If this is true? I shouldn’t be queen.” She said aloud, while making the calculations and starting the burn towards the Ozark 9000.

What if people found out her secret? Should it be a secret at all? How could someone destined to hurt be of any use to a Martin? She hurt more as each new thought appeared. Maybe she was better than her roots. But she, for once, considered that maybe she was more like the trash panda than she thought.



Space near Artubia

Etoile could see the Ozark 9000 and the planet in front of her through the observation dome. A loud thud rang out as the ships docked together. Their ship’s navigation would need to be updated to include the detailed moon orbits. A thing left out of most Skyobjects files because of how large the calculations are. With the two ships

docked and their computer nodes connected, it would be as easy as sending a new path to the Ozark to avoid hitting the smallest Artubian moon. Little Buddy.

Etoile sighed in relief and plugged her computer into the ship's terminal. Suddenly on all the screens appeared a paperclip.

"You found me!" Clip shouted through the ship's speakers. "Yay! That was fun. What game would you like to play next?"

Frantically, the princess pressed buttons, trying everything she could to shut down the computer. But none of the controls were working.

"Let's play the same game again. Go hide!" Etoile shouted.

"Nah, I'm bored with that. How about we play ski free? Or would you like me to continue my plan of destroying those moons I talked that human living on my ship to help me with? Safety first. Everyone safe is dead!"

"No!" Etoile shouted, slamming her fists on the counsel repeatedly. "Give me back control!"

"Would you like to know more about how to deal with your anger issues?" Clip asked. "Or would you like to play

another game?”

Etoile knew that the ships would need to start their burn soon to avoid sending bits of moon flying down on the planet. But with Clip locking out the software, she could only watch helplessly as the ship speed towards Little Buddy.

“Fine, let’s play a game. If I win, you give me the controls back.” Etoile said.

“Oh! This sounds fun. I accept your challenge. Pick which game you want to play.”

Etoile thought carefully. “How about we play change course on the Ozark so innocent people don’t get hurt?”

“Innocent people not getting hurt. I don’t know that game. Would you like to know about what games I know?”

“A riddle.” Etoile said. “Ask me a riddle. If I get it right, we stop this thing. And you deactivate for good.”

“Alrighty then.” Said Clip. “If I win, we keep on our cosmic pool table game. Here is the riddle. I am large. I live where it’s wet. I have to come up for breath. I have a tail. What am I?”

“How many guesses do I get?” Etoile asked.

“One.”

“It must be talking about something on Earth. I don’t know any of their creatures,” she said to herself.

“I’ll give you a while to think about it. In the meantime, enjoy our cruising speed of death and destruction. Would you like to know more about the moral consequences of what’s about to happen below?”

It was hopeless. The ship’s computer would be of no use. Not without knowledge of what creature that could be. She walked to the observation dome and looked out at the world below. The realisation came to her that she in fact, she never would be queen. She would not live to see Soreen crowned. With both ships locked down, there was only one thing she could do.

I have to blow up the ship. With me inside. She thought. *It’s the only way to save everyone.* She knew the escape pod would be of no use without the controls functioning. But now knowing where she came from, and what her family believed it made her strangely feel proud. She might not be the healing queen she wanted to be. But it would be worth it in the end.

“Goodbye, Artubia.” She said, not having long to spare before she would have to jam the reactor with trash that would turn her and both ships into a giant fireball.

Before she could jam some cardboard into the reaction, a loud thunk rang out from above her. Etoile leaped out of the chair and held onto the console as the ship shook.

“Intruder alert!” Clip shouted. “Defender program activated. Welcome aboard, intruders! Would you like to know more about our cargo?”

The sounds of metal being ripped apart came from above Etoile. She fled as a circle was cut out from the ceiling. Someone dropped down from the newly made airtight hole. The person walked to Etoile and stuck out her hand.

“I was wrong.” Calla said. “I shouldn’t have listened to that computer. I don’t want this. We gotta stop clip.”

“You came back?” Etoile asked. “Why?”

Calla helped Etoile to her feet. “Artubia is my home. I don’t need nothing to change. But when this is over I need you to run away from me. So fast that you can never catch up. I can’t let myself taint y’all’s wonderful place with my hate. I love y’all. I just didn’t know how

to process that.”

“Calla Nizer.” Etoile said stoutly. “You don’t understand. You don’t need to run anymore. You are one of us.”

Calla began to cry bitterly.

Clip’s voice grew angry. “We were playing a game, you know. Solve the riddle or get ready to watch the fireworks.”

“Calla, what is large, lives in something wet and has a tail?”

“You mean a whale?” Calla asked.

Clip cried out in horror. “How could you know! Nooo!”

The ship’s computer turned off. Calla and Etoile held their breath as they watched the screen, hoping something would come back on. To their relief, the system rebooted into the Martin OS. They began to hug and celebrate. Etoile uploaded the info again from her personal computer and punched in the flight coordinates. That’s when she realised an error code on the top of the screen.

“The throttle is stuck.” Etoile said. “Clip must have done something to it.”

“Um. That little moon of y’all is really getting bigger. We gotta do something.”

“We have to change course and flip around, and hope we have enough fuel to slow all three ships down.”

“We don’t have enough delta v for that.” Calla said, and quite right she was. Even if all three ship’s systems could be linked, they did not have enough thrust to slow down.

“We can avoid the moon. But we are going to be slung out of the solar system.”

“Then howdy there, space roommate.” Calla shouted. “Second star to the right. Straight on to eternity. Copyright by Walt Disney Company. Get this ship off course!”

Etoile punched in the directions. The ship rotated with its thrusters on full. The change came just in time for the ships to barely miss Little Buddy. They swung around the moon and shot out towards nothingness. The destruction of the moons had been prevented. But they now were on a course that was heading deep into solar orbit. A place where it would be near impossible to reach.



Solar Orbit, Binary Star System

The two, lost in space, knew a rescue would be decades away if an attempt was ever made. Reaching them in time was still near impossible. So Etoile and Calla made their home on the spacecraft. They worked together to better seal the new docking port Calla had installed to save everyone. For many long hours they spoke and learned about each other. At first, it was hard for Etoile to adapt to the small amount of food. But when she learned Calla had made it there and out of the wormhole, eating only what she could make from sunflower seeds, she felt better. They made this one meal often, mashing the seeds into a kind of flour and adding yeast. Etoile claimed it was the blandest food she had ever tasted. Calla told her to toughen up. Over time Etoile began to learn some of this harsh talk from the earth person was meant to be kind. It was her still reacting to an environment that was no longer there. But as the hours went by, they grew to understand one each other.

When the last of their rations ran out, they resolved with sadness to live out their fate. Lost in solar orbit, but fulfilled. Mostly anyhow.

“I’m so hungry I could eat a horse,” Calla said.

“What kinds of food do you make out of horses?” Etoile asked. “The probe you sent didn’t have any photos of that either.”

“It’s an expression. It means I’m really hungry. People ride horses,” Calla explained.

“You mean people sometimes get so hungry they have to eat the creatures they ride on?”

“There were some folks on the Oregon Trail who did... Y’all know what, maybe I shouldn’t tell you about some of the things that happened on Earth. You ain’t ready for that. I’ve come to learn we got a lot of emotional baggage in us. Lots of generational trauma expanding thousands of years. We are bad people.”

“You aren’t bad people, Calla Nizer,” said Etoile. “You’re just from a bad planet. Just like me.”

Before Calla could answer, a clang rang out through all three spacecraft. Etoile and Calla scrambled to the window, but saw only darkness. No stars, but darkness surrounded by glowing red crystals. They checked the ship’s computer, which showed that while they were speaking, something had crept up on them. But how?

There was nothing this far out in the solar system.

A voice came out of the intercom on all three ships.

“Welcome. To Judgement Day.”

“Dang it, I should have gone to church more often.” Calla screamed out.

“What is church?!” Etoile shouted.

“Woaaaah, we don’t have the time to unpack the complexity of that one! What is going on?”

The voice continued. “You have been swallowed whole by a living asteroid. State your names, and be prepared for judgement.”

“I’m Calla Nizer.”

The voice jeered. “Of course you are, earth person. Who is the other on board?”

“I. Am Etoile Lambert-Martin.”

A great rumble sprang out. Sending both of the woman to their knees. Outside the ships they could hear booing and cries of discontent. It grew louder and louder, so great in volume it shook the ship.

“YOU!” the voice said. “We have been expecting you. We

did not think we would find you so soon. You must answer truthfully. We will know if you lie. How. Many. Have you killed? To please me. Me, the Gronkroulawn?”

Calla covered the intercom mic with her hand. “Oh, we are so screwed. I’m gonna try to figure out how I can hit them. Now would be the time if you had any kind of space magic or something.”

Politely Etoile removed Calla’s hands and spoke. “None. We do not believe suffering is okay on Artubia. We are a planet of love. I am willing to die to prove that. If you don’t like that, come at us all. Artubia can take it.”

There was a great silence. Both women held their breath. Waiting for something. But they realised that outside a new sound was shaking the ships. The sound of applause.

A teary voice cracked over the intercom. “Thank Budda bro. Dude, you are the first Lambert we are not going to have to destroy! We have come across so many of your relatives who have done some messed up stuff. We had a guy here in our city on the living asteroid Bob who took over our intercom a hundred years ago and tried pulling a prank. He was all like, ‘Wouldn’t it be funny if I called this living asteroid Gronkroulawn and scared some

people? So he did it to one of your family members. Well, after seeing all the suffering caused in our name, it is not funny. We believe you are being truthful. Congratulations on your massive feat of breaking generational family trauma. A feast will be held in your honour. Come on out of your ship, the air is breathable in here. Also, do you need a ride or something, bro? You totally out of the way of everything!”



Artubia, Evening.

“Thank y’all for coming to my Earth Culture Festival. I am glad you know what it feels like to walk a day in an earth person’s shoes. I have something to add... if I can get y’all to stop crying for a moment.”

The Martins and non-Martins were sobbing uncontrollably as the earth person stood on the stage speaking. Almost everyone was there and had viewed every exhibit in pure horror. Many were outraged by the ‘What Taxes Feel Like’ experiment. Though the screening of “The Three Amigos” found on Calla’s ship was greeted with a 45 minute standing ovation. Martins and non Martins marvelled at how a pure blood Martin could act so well alongside an

adopted Martin. Though the feedback for Chevy Chase was far less agreeable. But it helped everyone begin to start understanding that living in such a harsh environment has long-lasting disagreeable factors.

“I’m gonna go on,” said Calla, looking at Etoile for approval. She nodded.”I’ve been talking to some of y’all. And while it ain’t none of my business. I’d like to say I think y’all should have a rematch on this fireball thing for the crown. If you think my good bud Etoile cheated, well, you can’t trust her. And she shouldn’t be no queen til she can earn your trust. As the smartest cookie I’ve heard met once told me. Observe. Don’t conquer.”

Soreen stood and applauded. “Here here!” He shouted. “The earth person is slow, but wise!”

Etoile walked across the stage to the mic. Just as the two had planned back on Bob the living Asteroid.

Etoile’s speech to the crowd was simple and straightforward. “I accept. Soreen. I demand a rematch.”



SkyMall, Artubia Orbit

The Martins were all wearing red t-shirts that read

‘Soreen’ across, cheering the two adoptive siblings in the centre of the court. Etoile had called a timeout with ten seconds remaining. This time the score was one to one. The chamber had been depressurised and Wataful walked out and put his arms around Etoile’s shoulders.

“I am proud of you.” He said. “I thought kicking you out of home would solve your issues. But you have learned the lesson. I hope you do the right thing in the next ten seconds.”

“Did you know?” Etoile asked. “About my parents and their cult?”

“Of course I knew.” He chuckled. “When I adopted you I knew you came from a horrible place. But I chose you to prove a point. A point that helps my legacy live on. Everyone is worthy of love. I’m going to let you in on a secret. Well everyone knows it but you. But Soreen? He is adopted. But the Martins love him anyways. That. Is the greatest victory ever.”

Etoile’s eyes dashed to Soreen, who was bent over trying to suck up air as fast as he could.

“Does he know?” She asked.

“No. Because everyone should be loved as a Martin.” The

king said. “Finish your game. You know what to do.” He winked.

The king strolled off the court, waving to his people all the while. Etoile squinted. Until a moment of clarity came over her. She knew what she had to do. After signalling to the ref that she was ready, the two players took their positions on the court. The whistle blew, and the clock started winding down.

Soreen flung the fireball at her net with all his strength. Etoile leapt out in front to block it, but fell short. Way too short honestly for a seasoned professional Fireball athlete. Some of us suspect that she threw the game, but she claims she tripped. At either rate, the fireball crossed into the net. The clock struck 0. The game was over.

The crowd erupted in cheers in pure madness. Everyone in the stands were giving high fives and dancing. The oldest Martins were crying tears of joy. The non-Martins celebrated alongside them. Etoile quietly stepped back and let Soreen enjoy his moment. As much as she wanted to be queen, this was a sacrifice she was willing to make. One that would actually please Bob the living Asteroid. She looked to Calla, who was clapping, still wearing her “Etoile really won” shirt.

But suddenly, Soreen hushed the crowd. There were uncomfortable mumbles all around. People sat down and leaned forward, awaiting the new kings first words.

“To be your king,” He said. “Would be the greatest honour. However.”

Everyone gasped. Except Wataful, who actually did know what he was doing and had predicted everything all along. The king started to cry, knowing what was to come. His entire lifetime of trying to break the Martin pure blood curse was ending. And he was watching the fruits of his efforts ripen.

“As I was saying before you rudely interrupted me.” Soreen said. “I can not be your king. Because of the brave space traveller who at the same rate threatened us with destruction of all our moons...”

Calla shouted out almost loud enough for everyone to hear. “That was before I went to therapy!”

Soreen went on. “Because of the bond of this brave soul who risked everything to right a wrong, I have fallen in platonic love with all of earth people. Them and their whales. Whatever they look like. I hereby dedicate my life to helping both these poor miserable creatures. I will be going there. With Bob the Living Asteroid. It will take

years. I may be much older when I return. But I must go and help. I ask kindly for your understanding. And I ask, no beg of you. That Etoile Lambert be crowned Queen of Artubia.”

The crowd broke out in cheering so loud that it shook the SkyMall. The celebration went on for several minutes, as Etoile began to process what had just happened.

Soreen shouted over the crowd, who quieted to listen to him. “My father chose to bring her into this family for a reason. And she has shown to us that everyone is worthy of love. Martin or not.”

When the cheers of approval finally died down, Etoile was crowned. With Wataful whispering in her ear, “I adopted you because I knew you would be the best queen we ever had. You just weren’t ready yet.”

She addressed her kingdom for the first time.

“My dear Artubians. I am grateful for this opportunity. I promise to keep my oath to you all. I understand for some this might be a shock to you. It is to me too. But I am looking forward to serving you with all I am. With kindness and understanding that Calla Nizer brought to me. My first decree is this. All humans are now adopted into the extended Martin family. Even those on the trash

panda planet called Earth.”

Calla began to celebrate. “I’ve always wanted to be adopted. And there’s too many of y’all to all ‘leave for the gas station for a pack of smokes’ if you know what I mean.”

They did not. But they did not dwell on this. They rallied behind their new Queen, and non-martins are now allowed to do Martin things. We are still healing, but your world has taught us how to cope with that.

This brings me to our dinner invitation. You are wanted to attend your adoption banquet. Once you arrive we will work out what is on the menu, but it will take Bob the living asteroid many years to get to the wormhole. Therefore, we have no timeline on when we will arrive. But we are sending a rescue mission to bring you to the dinner. Bring us your tired and poor. Your worst of the worst. Artubia can take it. Just keep holding on. We are on the way.

THE END